CSRA MARKETING

A FREE GUIDE FOR ROOFING COMPANY OWNERS

The Roofing SEO Playbook

What every roofing company owner should know about getting found on Google, before spending a single dollar on SEO.

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INTRODUCTION

Why I Wrote This

I talk to roofing company owners every week. And I keep hearing the same two stories.

Story one goes like this: "We paid for SEO for eight months. Every month we got a report full of words we did not understand. The phone never rang. We canceled."

Story two goes like this: "Google sends us five or ten extra jobs a month now. We barely think about it. It just works."

Same service. Same internet. Completely different outcomes.

Here is what I have learned after years in this business: the difference between those two owners is rarely luck. The first owner bought something he did not understand, from someone who counted on that. The second owner understood what he was buying, what it should produce, and how long it should take. That understanding is the whole game.

I wrote this playbook to give you that understanding.

I am not going to teach you how to do SEO yourself. You run a roofing company. You do not have time to become a marketer, and you should not have to. What you need is simpler: enough knowledge to buy SEO wisely, to spot nonsense from a mile away, and to know whether the money you spend is actually turning into roofs.

That is what these pages do. In plain English, with no jargon, I will show you how Google actually decides which roofer to show, the three things that move your rankings, what a realistic timeline looks like, how to measure results that matter, the red flags that should send you running, and the simple profit math that tells you when SEO has paid for itself.

A quick note on honesty: I run an agency that does SEO for roofing companies. I am telling you that up front because I want you to read this the right way. This guide will not pressure you to hire anyone, including me. Plenty of what is in here will help you even if you never spend a dollar with an agency. What I will not do is pretend SEO is magic, instant, or right for everyone. It is none of those things. It is a tool. This playbook shows you how the tool works, so you can decide whether it belongs in your business.

One more thing before we start. Everything in here is written the way I would explain it sitting across from you at a kitchen table. If a sentence sounds like it came from a marketing textbook, I failed. Let us get into it.

CHAPTER 1

How Roofing SEO Actually Works, in Plain English

What Google is trying to do

Google has one job: answer the searcher's question as well as possible, as fast as possible. When a homeowner types "roof replacement near me" at 9 p.m. with water coming through the ceiling, Google wants to show the roofer most likely to solve that problem well. Every time Google gets it right, that homeowner trusts Google a little more. That trust is Google's entire business.

This is not a small corner of the internet. Google has said that nearly half of all searches have local intent, meaning the searcher is looking for something nearby (Google). And among people who search on a phone for something nearby, 76% visit a business within a day (Google). Your next customer is already searching. The only question is whose name they see.

Where you can show up

When someone searches for a roofer, your business can appear in three places:

- **The map pack.** The map with three business listings at the top of the results. This is the money spot. Most roofing calls from Google start here.
- **The regular results below the map.** These are pages from your website. They catch the searchers who scroll past the map, and they build the trust that turns a click into a call.
- **Your business profile panel.** The box showing your reviews, hours, photos, and phone number. This is what the homeowner studies before deciding who to call.

What SEO actually is

SEO is the work of convincing Google, in the language Google understands, that you are the best answer for that homeowner. Google cannot climb onto your roofs. It cannot watch your crew work. So it reads signals: what your website says, what your customers say about you in reviews, whether other local websites mention you, and how complete and active your business profiles are.

Why roofers win or lose

Roofers lose for boring reasons, not mysterious ones. Google cannot find enough proof that they are real, active, and trusted. Their website is five pages from 2019. Their business profile is half finished. They have eleven reviews and their competitor has two hundred. Or a competitor simply has more proof: more reviews, more mentions around the web, a website that clearly explains every service in every town they serve. Google is not punishing anyone. It is just showing the business it has the most evidence for.

> **WORTH REMEMBERING**
>
> Google does not rank the best roofer. It ranks the roofer it has the most proof about. Your job, whether you do the work yourself or hire help, is to give Google more proof than the next guy.

Now that you know what Google wants, let us look at the three specific things it measures. That is Chapter 2.

CHAPTER 2

The 3 Things That Move Your Rankings

Google has publicly said that local rankings come down to three things: relevance, distance, and prominence (Google). You do not need a marketing degree to understand them. Here is each one in plain English, with why it matters for your roofing company.

1. Relevance: do you match what the searcher wants?

Relevance is Google asking one question: does this business do the thing this person is searching for? If someone searches "metal roof repair," Google looks for roofers whose website and business profile clearly talk about metal roof repair. Not roofers who "do it all." Roofers who specifically do that thing, in that place.

Why it matters for roofers: most roofing websites hurt themselves right here. One page says "residential and commercial roofing services" and expects Google to figure out the rest. Google will not figure it out. It will show the competitor whose site plainly covers metal roof repair in that town instead. The principle is simple: be specific about every service you offer and every town you serve. Vague websites get vague rankings.

2. Distance: how close are you to the searcher?

Distance is exactly what it sounds like. All else equal, Google shows the roofer closer to the searcher. You cannot move your office, and you should not try to game this. But you can take something useful from it: you will win searches near you far more easily than searches forty miles away. For the farther towns, relevance and prominence have to do the heavy lifting.

Why it matters for roofers: this is why "we serve the whole metro area" on your website is not a strategy. Decide which towns actually produce jobs for you, and make sure Google sees you as the obvious choice in each of them. Distance sets the playing field. The other two factors decide who wins on it.

3. Prominence: how well-known and trusted do you look?

Prominence is Google's word for reputation. It is built from everything Google can observe about your standing: your reviews, how many other websites mention or recommend you, how complete and active your business profile is, and how long you have been around.

This is where reviews do their heaviest lifting. 82% of U.S. adults say they at least sometimes read online customer ratings or reviews before choosing a business (Pew Research Center). Google sees that behavior too. A roofer with 200 recent reviews looks like a safer answer than one with 12, and Google acts accordingly. Google's own research also found that customers are 2.7 times more likely to consider a business reputable when its Business Profile is complete (Google). Completeness is free. Most roofers still skip it.

Why it matters for roofers: prominence is the tiebreaker. When two roofers are equally relevant and equally close, the one with more reviews, more mentions around the web, and a complete profile wins the call. Almost every ranking battle between good roofers is decided right here.

> **THE TAKEAWAY**
>
> You cannot change your distance. So the entire game is relevance plus prominence: be unmistakably clear about what you do and where you do it, and build a reputation Google cannot ignore. Everything in this playbook ladders up to those two.

CHAPTER 3

What to Expect Month by Month

Let me be straight with you: anyone who promises you page one in 30 days is selling something, not telling you something. SEO is slow because trust is slow. Google needs time to notice changes, and it needs to see consistency before it rewards you. Here is the honest timeline I walk every roofing company through.

Phase	What Is Happening	What You Will See
Months 1 to 2: Foundation	Your website's technical problems get fixed, your business profiles get completed, call tracking gets set up so results can be counted, and a system for earning reviews goes in place.	Not much yet, and that is normal. The groundwork for everything else is being laid behind the scenes.
Months 3 to 4: Early signals	New pages go live covering your services and towns, reviews start accumulating, and other local websites begin mentioning your company.	Your business starts appearing in searches more often. A few extra calls trickle in. Nothing dramatic.
Months 5 to 6: Traction	Google has now seen months of consistent signals. Your review count pulls away from competitors who stood still.	Map pack appearances become regular. Call volume from Google grows month over month.
Month 6 and beyond: Compounding	Every review, page, and mention stacks on top of the last. Competitors now have to outrun a moving target.	Google becomes a steady source of jobs. The cost of each lead keeps falling because you are not paying per click.

A working guideline based on what I see across roofing markets. Competitive metros can run longer; quiet towns can move faster.

Why it takes this long

Three reasons. First, Google re-crawls the web on its own schedule, not yours. Changes you make today can take weeks to even be noticed. Second, trust is earned through

consistency. One good month of reviews does not prove much; six good months proves a pattern. Third, your competitors are not standing still. You are climbing a hill that moves.

Think of it like planting. Months 1 to 2 are digging the hole. You do not dig for a week and then complain there is no shade.

What impatience costs

The most expensive SEO mistake I see is quitting at month three. The owner paid for the foundation, then walked away right before the house went up. If you cannot commit to at least six months, save your money. SEO bought in three-month bursts is just donations to whoever sold it to you.

> **BE HONEST WITH YOURSELF**
>
> Before you start, ask: "Am I willing to invest for six months before judging the results?" If the answer is no, SEO is not your channel right now. That is a perfectly fine answer. It is far better than an expensive lesson.

CHAPTER 4

How to Tell If Your SEO Is Actually Working

Rankings are a vanity metric. You cannot deposit a ranking in the bank. Here is the uncomfortable truth most SEO reports hope you never notice: you can rank number one and still get no calls, if you rank for searches nobody types or your business profile looks untrustworthy when people find it. So let us talk about what actually matters.

The only three numbers that matter

1. Phone calls from Google. Ask every caller how they found you, and use a separate tracking number on your website so online calls get counted on their own. If this number is not growing, nothing else in the report matters.

2. Quote requests and form fills. Not every homeowner calls. Count every estimate request that comes through the website, and note which ones came from a Google search.

3. Booked estimates. Calls are interest. Booked estimates are pipeline. Track how many Google-sourced calls turn into someone climbing a ladder at the house. This is the number your revenue actually comes from.

The early signs, before the calls come

In the first few months, the calls have not caught up yet. That is expected. Here is how you know the foundation is working anyway:

- Your business shows up in searches more often than before.
- More people view your business profile, call straight from it, or request driving directions.
- Your review count and star rating keep climbing.
- Website visitors from your service area grow month over month.

These are leading indicators. They tell you the engine is warming up while the calls catch up.

How to read any SEO report in 60 seconds

Skip the jargon. Ask three questions:

1. How many calls did Google send me this month?
2. Is that number bigger than last month?
3. What did we do this month to earn next month's calls?

Any provider worth paying should answer all three in plain English, without making you feel dumb for asking.

> **THE 60-SECOND TEST**
>
> One question cuts through every report you will ever receive: "How many calls did Google send me this month, and is it more than last month?" If the answer is vague, the results probably are too.

CHAPTER 5

Red Flags When Hiring SEO Help

Most SEO companies are not criminals. But this industry has a long tail of operators who survive on one fact: owners cannot tell good work from theater. Here are the red flags I tell every roofer to watch for. Any one of them is a reason to walk away.

1. They guarantee rankings

Nobody can guarantee Google's results. Not me, not anyone. Google says so itself. A guarantee of page one is a confession: they are either lying, or they plan to rank you for searches nobody types so the "guarantee" is easy to keep.

2. Their methods are "secret" or "proprietary"

Real SEO is boring and explainable: fix the website, complete the profiles, earn reviews, publish useful pages, earn mentions around the web. If they cannot describe what they will do each month in words a teenager would understand, they are hiding either incompetence or shortcuts that can get you penalized.

3. No reporting, or reports full of jargon

If you cannot tell from their report how many calls you got, that is not an accident. Go back to Chapter 4 and demand the 60-second test every single month. A provider who drowns you in charts but never mentions calls is selling you fog.

4. Suspiciously cheap

Good SEO is labor: writing, outreach, technical work, review systems. If the price sounds like a bargain, the work is either automated, outsourced to nobody, or nonexistent. You will get a monthly PDF and a prayer. Cheap SEO is the most expensive kind, because it costs you the months you could have spent building something real.

5. They want to own your website or accounts

Never agree to this. Your domain, your website, your business profiles, your ad accounts: all in your name, with you as the owner, from day one. If a provider holds your assets hostage when you try to cancel, you did not hire a marketer. You rented one, at whatever price they name.

6. Long lock-in contracts with no performance conversation

SEO takes months, so some commitment is fair. But a 12-month lock with no check-ins, no targets, and no way out is a trap. A confident provider puts milestones in writing and talks about them with you. If they will not discuss what success looks like at month three and month six, they do not plan to be measured.

What good looks like

It helps to know what you are looking for, not just what to avoid. A provider worth your money will:

- Give you a plain-English plan: what they will do each month, and why.
- Report on calls and booked estimates, not jargon.
- Leave you owning every account and every piece of content.
- State honest timelines up front. Six months before judging, said on day one.
- Ask about your business: your margins, your best towns, your close rate. If they do not care how you make money, they cannot make you more of it.

> **THE DINNER TABLE TEST**
>
> If you cannot explain what you are paying for to your spouse at the dinner table, do not sign. "They do SEO stuff" is not an explanation. It is a hope with a monthly fee.

CHAPTER 6

The ROI Math: What One Roof Is Worth

Forget everything about traffic, impressions, and domain authority. There is exactly one math problem that decides whether SEO is worth it for your company. Let us do it together.

Step 1: your gross profit per roof

Take your average roof replacement price. Multiply it by your gross margin. That is what one extra job is actually worth to you.

For illustration, here is the example I use with every roofer. These are example numbers, not yours. Run the same two multiplications with your real numbers before you go any further.

Line	Illustrative Value
Average roof replacement price	**$12,000** (illustrative)
Gross margin	**40%** (illustrative)
Gross profit per roof	**$4,800** (illustrative)

Illustrative example. Plug in your own average job size and margin.

Now look at what a few extra roofs a month mean over a year, using those same illustrative numbers:

Extra Roofs per Month	Extra Gross Profit per Month	Extra Gross Profit per Year
1	$4,800	$57,600
2	$9,600	$115,200
3	$14,400	$172,800

Illustrative example based on a $12,000 roof at 40% margin. Your numbers will differ.

Step 2: the break-even question

Now take whatever you pay for SEO each month and divide it by your gross profit per roof. That is how many extra roofs a month the campaign needs to produce to pay for itself.

I am deliberately not naming a price here, because your market and your provider set that. But do the division with your own numbers. For most roofing companies, the answer is less than one roof a month. Let that sink in. SEO does not need to transform your business to pay for itself. It needs to produce a handful of extra roofs a year.

Step 3: why the math gets better over time

Here is the part paid ads cannot match. With ads, every call has a price, forever. The day you stop paying, the calls stop. SEO builds an asset. Once you rank, the calls keep coming without a per-click cost attached. So month twelve of SEO almost always looks better than month three: the same effort, more calls, a lower cost per lead. The math compounds. That is the entire argument for sticking with it past the slow start.

One more illustration to make it concrete. Say Google sends you 20 extra calls a month (illustrative), and you close 30% of them into booked jobs (illustrative; use your real close rate). That is 6 extra roofs. At $4,800 of gross profit each (illustrative), that is $28,800 a month in gross profit from a single channel. Now you see why the roofers in story two from the introduction "barely think about it."

> **THE ONLY QUESTION**
>
> Do not ask "Is SEO expensive?" Ask "How many extra roofs a month does it need to produce?" Then divide by your gross profit per roof. Owners who do this math never get fooled by a monthly fee again.

YOUR NEXT STEP

See Exactly What Is Holding Your Website Back

You now know more about roofing SEO than most owners who have paid for it for years. You know how Google thinks, the three things it measures, what a realistic timeline looks like, how to measure what matters, which red flags to run from, and the profit math that settles every "is it worth it" debate.

Knowledge is only useful if you act on it. So here is my suggestion for your next step: get a free website audit.

Your Free Website Audit

I will personally look at your website and your Google presence and show you **exactly what is helping you, what is hurting you, and what I would fix first** if your company were mine. Plain English. No jargon. No obligation.

It takes a few minutes to request, and you will walk away knowing precisely where you stand against the roofers ranking above you.

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Whether you ever hire anyone or not, you will make better decisions with that picture in front of you. That is what this playbook was for.

To your next roof,

Kemar Lawrence

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